

11+ Standard

bucks11plustest.co.uk

The Buckinghamshire 11+ Parent Guide

Understanding the grammar school test
and how to assess readiness.

Free educational resource — not affiliated with The Buckinghamshire Grammar Schools or GL Assessment

How the Bucks Grammar School System Works

The Secondary Transfer Test

The Buckinghamshire Secondary Transfer Test (commonly known as the "Bucks 11+") is the selective assessment used to determine eligibility for grammar school places in the county. It is administered by The Buckinghamshire Grammar Schools (TBGS) on behalf of all 13 grammar schools.

Children sit the test in September of Year 6. The test is designed to assess reasoning ability across three domains: Verbal Reasoning, Non-Verbal Reasoning, and Mathematics. It is not a test of curriculum knowledge — it measures underlying cognitive and reasoning skills.

The 13 Grammar Schools

Buckinghamshire has 13 state-funded grammar schools, making it one of the largest selective education systems in England. Schools are located across the county in Aylesbury, High Wycombe, Amersham, Beaconsfield, Chesham, Marlow, Burnham, Buckingham, and Little Chalfont.

All 13 schools use the same test result for qualification. However, each school has its own oversubscription criteria (typically distance-based) which determines who receives a place when more children qualify than there are places available.

The Year 6 Testing Process

Parents register their child during the summer term of Year 5 (May–June). Children then sit the test in September of Year 6 at an allocated test centre. Results arrive in mid-October, and parents submit school preferences on the common application form by 31 October. National Offer Day is 1 March.

Understanding the Score of 121

The qualifying score for Buckinghamshire grammar schools is a standardised score of 121. This score has been consistent for many years and represents performance significantly above the national average.

How Standardisation Works

Raw test scores are converted to standardised scores using age adjustment. This means that a child who is younger within the cohort (e.g., born in August) receives a slightly higher standardised score than an older child (born in September) who achieved the same raw score. This ensures fair comparison across the year group.

Score Range	Meaning
Below 110	Below qualifying range
110 – 120	Within reach of qualifying
121+	Qualifying standard
130+	Comfortably above qualifying

Achieving a score of 121 means the child qualifies for grammar school consideration. It does not guarantee a place — each school's oversubscription criteria then determine allocation when demand exceeds capacity.

Admissions Timeline

Year 4 — Awareness

Begin researching the Buckinghamshire grammar school system. Understand what the test involves and which schools serve your area. No formal preparation is needed at this stage.

Year 5 — Preparation Begins

Start structured familiarisation with the three test domains: verbal reasoning, non-verbal reasoning, and mathematics. Focus on building foundational reasoning skills and understanding the question formats. Register for the test during the summer term (May–June).

Year 6 — Test & Applications

Sit the Secondary Transfer Test in September. Receive results in mid-October. Submit school preferences on the common application form by 31 October. National Offer Day is 1 March.

Key Dates Summary

- May–June Year 5: Registration opens
- September Year 6: Test date
- Mid-October Year 6: Results released
- 31 October Year 6: School preference deadline
- 1 March Year 7: National Offer Day

The Biggest Preparation Challenge

Many families complete large numbers of practice questions — often hundreds of papers — without knowing whether their child's performance is actually improving in the areas that matter most.

The challenge is not a lack of practice material. It is a lack of measurement. Parents often cannot answer fundamental questions:

- Is my child's accuracy improving, staying flat, or declining?
- Which specific reasoning skills are weakest?
- Is pace a limiting factor, or is it accuracy?
- Would improving one domain have more impact than another?
- How far is my child from the 121 qualifying score?

A diagnostic approach — one that measures specific skills, identifies gaps, and tracks progress — provides the clarity that generic practice cannot.

This is the principle behind structured readiness assessment: instead of guessing, families can see exactly where their child stands and what to focus on first.

The Three Pillars of Effective Preparation

- Reasoning Ability — Building the foundational skills tested in VR, NVR, and Maths
- Timing Discipline — Developing the pace needed to complete questions within the time limit
- Consistency — Maintaining stable performance across different question types and conditions

Example Platform Dashboard

The 11+ Standard platform provides structured readiness analysis. After completing a diagnostic assessment, parents receive detailed insights including:

- Readiness Forecast — estimated score against the 121 qualifying standard
- Performance Band — colour-coded status (red / amber / green)
- Accuracy Metrics — percentage correct across each domain
- Pace Analysis — timing per question compared to expected benchmarks
- Skill Gap Identification — specific reasoning areas requiring focus
- Stability Tracking — consistency across multiple assessments

The platform analyses accuracy, timing, and performance stability across reasoning skills. Instead of guessing whether preparation is working, parents can see concrete evidence of progress.

Example: Readiness Summary

Estimated Score: 118

Band: Confident Amber (within reach)

Gap to 121: 3 points

Verbal Reasoning: 62% | Non-Verbal Reasoning: 74% | Mathematics: 81%

Measure Your Child's Bucks 11+ Readiness

Take a free 12-minute diagnostic assessment to see where your child stands against the 121 qualifying score.

Start Free Diagnostic

bucks11plustest.co.uk/free-diagnostic

bucks11plustest.co.uk

This guide is an independent educational resource designed to help families understand the Buckinghamshire 11+ system.
It is not affiliated with The Buckinghamshire Grammar Schools, GL Assessment, or any individual grammar school.